# Seth Strickland

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## Academic Appointments

**Proofs & Reasons — Computus Transcription Project** Pittsburgh, PA
*Principal Investigator* *Carnegie Mellon University*

2026 – Present

Lead the computus corpus and HTR/stylometry initiative on mathematical imagination and calculational technique in medieval manuscript culture (proofsandreasons.io).

**Proofs & Reasons** Pittsburgh, PA
*Researcher* *Carnegie Mellon University*

May 2026 – Sep 2026

NLP and digital-humanities research on the long-timescale development of mathematical imagination and the ways calculational techniques hybridize with a broader spiritual and mystical imaginary.

**Carnegie Mellon University** Aug 2023 – Present
*Lecturer – Writing and Communications* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- **Courses Taught:** 76-106: Poetry for Programmers – novel course design that unites philosophy of computer science and poetics.
  76-101: Hunger: Interpretation and Argument – developing markdown files to aid student critical engagement with corporate AI tools.
  76-270: Writing for the Professions.
- **Service:** Member, Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Working Group.

**Carnegie Mellon University, Department of English** Oct 2026 – Dec 2026
*Academic and Administrative Operations Advisor (Special Faculty)* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Extension of additional temporary part-time special faculty appointment (Oct 13 – Dec 31, 2026; ∼10–15 hrs/week), with updated title; alongside Lecturer appointment; reported to Christopher Warren, Head, Department of English.
- Graduate student recruitment: recruiting campaign, follow-up emails, and review of Dietrich College graduate applications.
- Refined graduate recruitment FAQs for public-facing consumption.
- Coordinated with staff and faculty on the PhD certificate launch.
- Collaborated with faculty on graduate student handbook reviews.
- RPT support for the department, working closely with the Department Head.
- Graduate student data review.
- Assessed departmental administrative structure governing academic affairs and current assignment of duties for academic administrative staff.
- Provided guidance on the need and structure of part-time adjunct appointments.

**Carnegie Mellon University, Department of English** Sep 2026 – Oct 2026
*Graduate Advisor (Special Faculty)* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Additional temporary part-time special faculty appointment (Sep 1 – Oct 12, 2026; ∼10 hrs/week), alongside Lecturer appointment; reported to Christopher Warren, Head, Department of English.
- Graduate student recruitment: recruiting campaign, follow-up emails, and review of Dietrich College graduate applications.
- Developed graduate recruitment FAQs using AI-assisted tools.
- Coordinated with staff and faculty on the PhD certificate launch.
- Collaborated with faculty on graduate student handbook reviews.
- RPT support for the department, working closely with the Department Head.
- Graduate student data review.

**Cornell University** Aug 2022 – May 2023
*Joseph F. Martino '53 Lecturer in Undergraduate Teaching* *Ithaca, NY*

- **Courses Taught:** Erotic Ecologies I & II; Medieval Dreams and Modern Insomnia.

**Cornell University** Aug 2017 – Dec 2021
*Instructor of Record* *Ithaca, NY*

- **Courses Taught:** Writing and Community Engagement; American Voices; Games and Contests (Writing about Place/Motion); Collecting Evidence (Mystery Stories).
- **Teaching Assistant:** Medical Humanities (Spring 2019).
- **Service:** President, Medieval Studies Graduate Organization; Graduate Policy and Liaison Committee Member.

**Saint Louis University** Aug 2014 – May 2016
*Instructor of Record* *St. Louis, MO*

- **Courses Taught:** Advanced Strategies in Rhetoric and Research.
- **Co-Founder:** Text Mining Initiative, Walter J. Ong, S.J., Center for Digital Humanities.
- **Service:** EGSO Event Planner and Treasurer; EGSO Committee Member; Graduate Student Association Representative for English.

## Education

**Cornell University** 2022
*Ph.D., Medieval Literature* *Ithaca, NY*

- Dissertation: "Rewrite this Book: Compilation and Experimental Literary Practices in *Piers Plowman* and Late Medieval English Book Culture"

*M.A., Medieval Literature* *2019*

**Saint Louis University** St. Louis, MO
*M.A., English* *2016*

- Thesis: "Double Vision: *Piers Plowman* and the Medieval Miscellany"

**Hillsdale College** Hillsdale, MI
*B.A., Classics and English Literature* *2012*

## Digital Humanities & Public Scholarship

**Computus Transcription Project** 2026 – Present
*Proofs & Reasons — Computus Corpus* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Assembled a new corpus of ∼40 computus manuscripts (8th–12th c.), sourced via IIIF from e-codices, BnF, NYPL, and Wellcome, producing first-time diplomatic transcriptions of ∼4,500 pages to date.
- Built the supporting HTR + LLM-correction pipeline (Kraken HTR, ∼351,000-line training corpus, ∼3% character-error rate), funded by an NSF ACCESS allocation on PSC Bridges-2; ongoing stylometric clustering and rolling-fingerprint analysis.

**Beatrice Institute — Collegiate Cultural Foundation Series** AY 2026–27
*Program Collaborator* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Co-proposed (with James DeMasi, Meredith McDonough Thornburgh, and Grant Martsolf) an eight-event undergraduate series (seven seminars + one lecture) on marriage, dating, mate selection, and sexual integrity; $20,000 CCF award without revision.
- Seminar leader: "Call Him Hither: Have We Ever Known How to Date?" (*Wing to Wing, Oar to Oar*; courtship, gender, and modern dating expectations).

**Research Party** 2025 – Present
*Creator & Developer* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Designed and launched Research Party, a digital humanities platform dedicated to revealing social networks and bias in bibliographies.
- Offers the possibility for expansion of bibliographies after analysis is complete.

**Digital Humanities Lab** 2025 – Present
*Co-Founder* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Establishing a working group for researchers in CMU's English department and beyond focused on practical digital and computational solutions to real research problems.

**Computational Humanities Research Group** Fall 2025 – Summer 2026
*Founder, Department Coordinator* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Became a required graduate seminar for CMU's English department.
- Coordinating events for CMU's English department in coordination with the Posner Center and CMU Libraries to give local digital humanities researchers a public platform.

**Issuing Citations** 2025 – Present
*Chair and Co-Founder* *Pittsburgh, PA*

- Established and coordinated a meeting space for graduate students to present WIP to peers from other disciplines.

**Glyph Machina** 2023 – Present
*Medievalist & Technical Liaison* *Remote*

- Updated an .xml visual editor and wrote software to expand Latin abbreviations automatically.
- Transcribed manuscripts to .xml format and corrected transcriptions in VS Code.
- Authored approved SBIR Pre-application documents and internal technical documentation.

**Public Works** 2022 – 2023
*Co-Founder* *Ithaca, NY*

- Co-founded and maintained an interdisciplinary lecture series aimed at connecting academic speakers with public audiences. (`www.publicworks.info`).

**Text Mining Initiative** 2014 – 2016
*Co-Founder* *St. Louis, MO*

- Co-founded a digital humanities working group aimed at genre identification through distant reading practices.

## Software & Tools

- **historical-ocr** (GitHub) — Self-contained orchestrator for computational-ready text from historical sources: print OCR (Tesseract), PDF/IIIF ingest, protocol YAML → TEI, and optional hooks to `transcription-shell` and `manuscript-fingerprint`. Now a contributing tool across several dissertation projects.
- **strigil** (GitHub) — Archival web scraper: high-quality PDFs, text, and images from digital-collection sources (NYPL Digital Collections, CONTENTdm, IIIF manifests, HathiTrust), stored locally with archival-quality image filtering and optional JS rendering (Playwright/Chromium) for dynamic pages.
- **transcription-shell** (GitHub) — Lineation → PageXML → LLM transcription following the Academic Handwriting Transcription Protocol; GUI and CLI with Glyph Machina, Kraken, or custom mask lineation; validated YAML output. Trained a Kraken HTR model on ∼351,000 annotated medieval-Latin lines (CREMMA, HTRomance) to a 3% character-error rate on held-out validation; cross-provider benchmark suite (Anthropic, Gemini, local Ollama) against ground truth; 125 commits.
- **manuscript-fingerprint** — Letter-height and book-level sizing tool for early English print (c. 1470–1700): Kraken line segmentation, height-ratio filtering ($\geq 0.55\times$ median line height), 14 distributional sizing channels (glyph height, ink area, aspect ratio, leading, . . . ), then ResNet glyph-encoder matching to attribute imprints to physical type cases via Print & Probability.
- **Research Party** (research-party.com) — Bibliographic analysis platform: compile role and social maps, coverage, synthesis, and exploratory Q&A over a citation corpus; integrates `bib-ocr` PDF citation ingest.
- **new-world-xml** (`nwxml`) (GitHub) — Maintained visual Page XML / ALTO editor for ground truth on scanned documents; Electron desktop app, successor to visual-page-editor (itself based on nw-page-editor). Used in the Glyph Machina transcription workflow, including Latin abbreviation expansion (expand-diplomatic).
- **reasoning-stylometry** (GitHub) — R/`stylo` pipeline underpinning *Proofs & Reasons*: classifies mathematical *reasoning style* (spatial/visual vs. symbolic/derivational) independently from *content* (geometric vs. algebraic) across JAMS papers, via `stylo::classify` / `rolling.classify`, leave-one-out cross-validation, and Delta distance tables. Externally validated against 31 independently-authored, human-declared style labels.
- **medieval-proof** — Genre and authorship stylometry for medieval Latin: Burrows's Delta with rolling-entropy genre-shift detection across 13 genre classes, trained on ∼16,900 text chunks (Latin Library, Boethius, Bede, Chaucer, . . . ); applied to whole-manuscript reports on NYPL and Wellcome computistical witnesses.

## Consulting

**Gilliam Writers Group** 2022 – Present
*Faculty* *New York, NY*

- Consult with creative and academic writers to bring writing projects to completion and to market.

## Publications & Creative Work

### Academic Publications

Zhang, Michael, Elise Wang, Charlotte Whatley, Seth Strickland, and Dylan Bannon (May 2026). *Democratizing the medieval English legal tradition*. arXiv: 2605.00977 [cs.CV]. URL: https://arxiv.org/abs/2605.00977.

Strickland, Seth (May 2025b). "III Middle English: Langland". In: *The Year's Work in English Studies* 104.1.

— (2025c). "Review of Elise Wang, The Making of Felony Procedure in Middle English Literature". In: *Law and History Review*.

— (May 2024c). "III Middle English: Langland". In: *The Year's Work in English Studies* 103.1. URL: https://academic.oup.com/ywes/advance-article/doi/10.1093/ywes/maae005/7679460?searchresult=1.

— (July 2023a). "III Middle English: Langland". In: *The Year's Work in English Studies* 102.1, pp. 171–263. URL: https://academic-oup-com.cmu.idm.oclc.org/ywes/article/102/1/171/7220008.

— (July 2022a). "III Middle English: Langland". In: *The Year's Work in English Studies* 101.1, pp. 185–282. URL: https://academic-oup-com.cmu.idm.oclc.org/ywes/article/101/1/185/6646567.

— (2022c). "Review of Arvind Thomas, Piers Plowman and the Reinvention of Church Law in the Late Middle Ages". In: *Recherche littéraire / Literary Research* 38.1, pp. 203–208. URL: https://www.peterlang.com/document/1275890.

### Creative Works

Strickland, Seth (July 2026). "'Magnifica Humanitas' and Bullshit Jobs. Pope Leo and David Graeber Count the Costs of Efficiency". In: *Pittsburgh Review of Books*. URL: https://pghrev.com/reading-pope-leo-with-david-graeber/.

— (2024a). "[My father didn't see the possum trundling]". In: *The Pierian*.

— (May 2024b). "[Nothing Can Express it]". In: *Stink Eye Magazine*. URL: https://stinkeyemagazine.com/seth-strickland/.

Strickland, Seth (2020). "A Certain Lie about the Phoenix". In: *Goodbye, Mexico: Poems of Remembrance*. Ed. by Sarah Cortez. Texas A&M University Press.

— (2015). "Imagination". In: *The Tower Light*.

— (2012a). "[When you know what it is to suffer]". In: *The Tower Light*.

— (2012b). "Garlic". In: *The Tower Light*.

— (2012c). "Orion". In: *The Tower Light*.

### Work in Progress

- "Computi as Mathematical Thought: A Stylometric Examination of Post-Aristotelian Shifts in Medieval Calculation" (in progress).
- "Medieval Timekeeping as a Counterpoint for AI-Enabled Time-Sensitive Systems" (accepted, *Pittsburgh Review of Books*).

## Invited Lectures (Selected)

**Digital Humanities Summer Institute (DHSI)** Montreal, QC

- "Designing Markdown Prompts for Automatic Text Recognition" (guest session, Automatic Text Recognition course) June 8, 2026

**The Beatrice Institute** Pittsburgh, PA

- "Call Him Hither: Have We Ever Known How to Date?" (CCF undergraduate seminar series) AY 2026–27
- "Reflections on Lucian Simon's 'Schola' (1926)" Aug 2025
- "Romantic Poetry: The Theology of Blake's Poison Tree" Mar 2025
- "Piers Plowman and Questions of Justice" Feb 2025
- "Old English Poetry: Dream of the Rood" Jan 2025
- "Reflections on Robert Gwathmey's 'Hoeing"' Aug 2024

**University of Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh, PA

- "The manuscripts of Piers Plowman" Sept 2023

**International Poetry Forum** Pittsburgh, PA

- "Albertus Magnus as Guidance for Ethics and AI" (Poets-in-Person series) Nov 2024

## Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

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| Collegiate Cultural Foundation Grant ($20,000) — co-proposed undergraduate series (marriage, dating, sexuality; AY 2026–27) | Beatrice Institute |
| ACCESS Research Allocation — "Transcriber Shell" (1,454 GPU-hours, PSC Bridges-2) | NSF ACCESS |
| Project & Proposals Award ($2000) | American Society for Legal History |
| Provost's Inclusive Teaching Fellowship ($5000) | Carnegie Mellon University |
| Centre for Medieval Literature Graduate Student Bursary | SDU / York |
| Cornell University Conference Research Travel Grant | Cornell University |
| Sage Fellowship | Cornell University |
| Alan Young-Bryant Poetry Award | Cornell University |
| Truman Capote PhD Writer's Award | Cornell University |
| President's Fund Travel Grant | Cornell University |
| Vatican Film Library Research Grant ($8000) | Saint Louis University |
| Donald Howard Travel Scholarship | New Chaucer Society |
| Saint Louis University Graduate Assistantship | Saint Louis University |
| Alan F. Hilfiker Endowed Graduate Scholarship | Saint Louis University |
| Newberry Renaissance Consortium Grant | Newberry Library |
| University Writing Services Mentor of the Month | Saint Louis University |

## Conference Presentations

Bannon, Dylan, Seth Strickland, Elise Wang, Charlotte Whatley, and Michael Zhang (2025). "Making the Law Legible: A Self-Correcting BERT-Like Transformer as Manuscript Transcription Aid". The 27th Conference of the Association for the Study of Law, Culture, and the Humanities.

Strickland, Seth (2025a). "Divine Daughters in Law". 27th Conference of the Association for the Study of Law, Culture, and the Humanities at Georgetown Law in Washington, D.C.

— (2025d). "The Brazen Head of Vector Analysis: Robert Grosseteste and Albertus Magnus as Technological Forerunners". Twentieth International Conference on Interdisciplinary Social Sciences | Minds and Machines: Artificial Intelligence, Algorithms, Ethics, and Order in Global Society.

— (2024d). "Reviewed for Publication: Heidi Wright's Designing an Online Reading and Writing Course: Content, Caveats, and Accessibility". Symposium on Second Language Writing. Tucson, AZ. November 15, 2024. URL: https://oli.cmu.edu/courses/reading-to-write-research-articles-across-the-disciplines/.

— (2023b). "The Last Medieval Scribe: John Colyns and Authorial Control". Public Works. Ithaca, NY.

— (2022b). "Playing Chicken with Fate: Fortunate Dreams of the Body in Chaucer's 'The Nun's Priest's Tale'". New Chaucer Society. Durham University.

Strickland, Seth (2022d). "Your Own Personal Archive: Piers Plowman and Innovations of Abstraction". Centre for Medieval Literature. The Danish Institute, Rome.

— (2019a). "'Speke, Parrot': Echoes of Romance in Harley 2252". Leeds International Medieval Congress. University of Leeds.

— (2019b). "Death in Unity: Skepticism, Wounds, and Epistemic Crises in Piers Plowman B.20". 7th International Piers Plowman Society Meeting. University of Miami.

— (2018). "Peace at Peace: Scales of Redemption in Piers Plowman". New Chaucer Society Biennial Congress. University of Toronto.

— (2016). "Incest and the Grammar of the Gloss: Productive Omission in Pericles and Confessio Amantis". IV International Congress of the John Gower Society. Apollonius and Pericles: Manuscripts, Rhetoric, Performance, and Desire. Durham University.

Strickland, Seth, Helen Davies, and Margaret Smith (2016). "Roundtable: Doing DH: Opportunities and Challenges for Graduate Students in the Digital Humanities". 4th Annual Symposium on Medieval and Renaissance Studies. Saint Louis University.

Strickland, Seth, Jonathan Sawday, Lauren Kersey, and Geoffrey Brewer (2016). "Which Time Is It? Digital Queries and Early Modern Period Schemes". The Walter J. Ong Symposium on Digital Humanities. Saint Louis University.

**Service & Organization**

- **Organizer:** 7th International Piers Plowman Society (Miami, FL); TMI Inaugural Conference (St. Louis).
- **Panel Organizer:** Activism I & II (IPPS); Slaughterhouse Vibes (SLU Symposium).
- **Session Chair:** Futures of Tradition (Cornell); Activism II (IPPS); Chaucerian Narratives (Illinois Medieval Association).

## Skills & Languages

**Research Languages:**

- *Professional/Advanced:* Latin, Middle English, Old English
- *Intermediate/Reading:* French (B1), Old Norse, German
- *Basic:* Spanish, Italian, Old French, Attic Greek

**Technical Skills:**

- *Programming Languages & Formats:* Python, R, Julia, JavaScript, HTML5, LaTeX, XML/TEI, PageXML, ALTO, YAML
- *Computational Humanities & Stylometry:* Computational Text Analysis, Distant Reading, Text Mining, `stylo` (R Package)
- *AI, ML & Computer Vision:* Computer Vision (ResNet glyph encoding), Transformers (BERT-like architectures), LLM Prompting Protocols, OCR Engines (Kraken, Tesseract)
- *Tools & Environments:* VS Code, NW.js, Git/GitHub, Linux, CLI/GUI Pipeline Orchestration